

China Outlook

Growth is lower and bifurcated

Softer PMIs and high-frequency data suggest growth momentum weakened visibly in Q2 as front-loaded fiscal stimulus fades. The PMI details continue to paint a picture of bifurcated growth, with strength in high-tech and export-oriented sectors, and weakness in traditional and domestic demand.

Following broad-based slowdown in April, May PMIs and high-frequency data suggest further weakening in growth momentum, mainly driven by softer domestic demand and some supply disruptions in petrochemical sectors. Such developments justify our base case of a visible slowdown in sequential growth momentum from 6.8% q/q saar in Q1 to 3.2% in Q2. China's NBS manufacturing PMI edged down to 50.0 in May from 50.3 in April, in line with our forecast and consensus. The slowdown was led by consumer goods and petrochemical-related sectors. Meanwhile, the RatingDog manufacturing PMI, which covers more export-oriented firms, came in stronger than market expectations at 51.8 in May (still quite strong vs 50.3 in 2025 and 51.4 YTD 2026), though it softened from a five-year high of 52.2 in April.

Despite a softer headline PMI, the details suggest China remains a two-speed economy. We think the May PMIs breakdown data, along with high-frequency data (weaker consumption and property vs robust exports), continues to paint a picture of bifurcated growth, with strength in high-tech and export-oriented sectors, and weakness in traditional and domestic demand (see [China: April reality check: supply can't lift demand](#), 18 May 2026).

- **Weakened sectors:** From an industry perspective, the slowdown in headline official NBS PMI was mainly led by: 1) oil related sectors, amid feedstock disruptions linked to the Middle East conflict; and 2) consumer goods. The PMIs for industries, including petroleum and fuel processing, and petrochemical-related sectors (chemical fibers, rubber and plastic products) were in contraction territory, with both demand (new orders) and supply indicators (production) pointing to weakness due to feedstock shortages amid the ongoing closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Moreover, it is worth noting the consumer goods PMI fell by 1pp, to 49.7, in May, pointing to weaker private consumption.
- **Improved sectors:** In contrast, the high-tech manufacturing and equipment manufacturing sectors continued to improve in May. The PMI for high-tech manufacturing rose to a 20-month high of 52.9, and the PMI for equipment manufacturing increased to a three-year high of 52.1. In particular, the production index and new orders index for sectors such as pharmaceuticals; railway, shipbuilding, aerospace and other transportation equipment, and for computers, communications, and electronic equipment all stood above 53.0, indicating relatively strong activity in both supply and demand.

In terms of profitability, we think the Middle East conflict has had an uneven impact on profitability across supply chains. Upstream sectors (energy and petrochemicals) have emerged as relative winners, while downstream sectors (consumer goods) face greater pressure.

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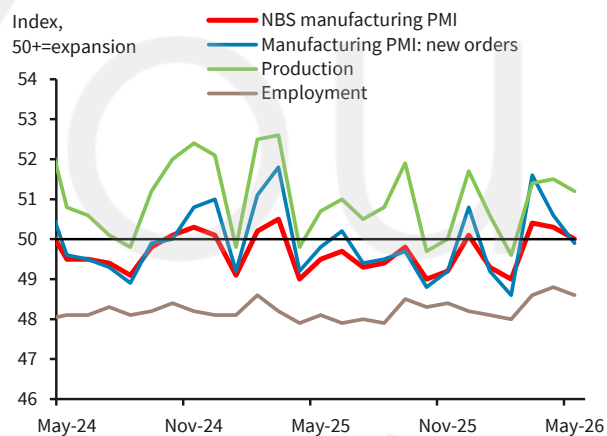
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Post-conflict PMI surveys suggest that although input prices have risen sharply across manufacturing, the pass-through to output prices has remained relatively limited. Notably, the gap between output and input prices widened to a four-year high in May, pointing to mounting margin compression in downstream sectors. This dynamic is also reflected in price indicators: PPI inflation surged to a near four-year high of 2.8% y/y in April, while CPI inflation remained soft at 1.2%.

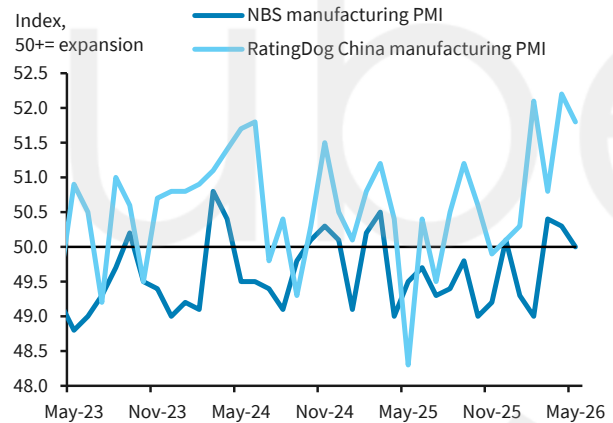
In terms of growth drivers, we expect net exports to continue to contribute about 30% of GDP growth this year (2025: 32%), adding 1.4pp to our full-year 2026 GDP growth forecast of 4.6%. The strength in exports will be led by green-tech and AI-related exports. By contrast, the contribution from consumption is likely to fall below 50% given: 1) a deteriorating labour market amid structural headwinds, such as supply chain relocation and China's transition towards less labour-intensive high tech manufacturing; 2) a smaller scale of pro-consumption trade-in subsidies, declining by 20% to CNY250bn in 2026 YTD; and 3) a negative wealth effect from continued declines in home prices, albeit at a slower pace.

FIGURE 1. NBS manufacturing PMI fell to 50 in May from 50.3 in April, in line with expectations



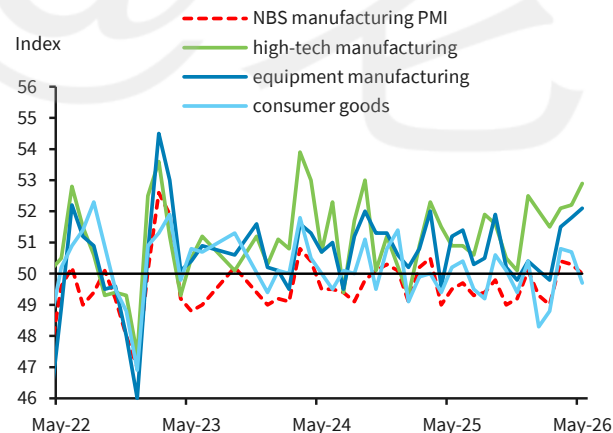
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. RatingDog PMI, which covers more export-oriented firms, continued to outperform the NBS PMI by a wide margin



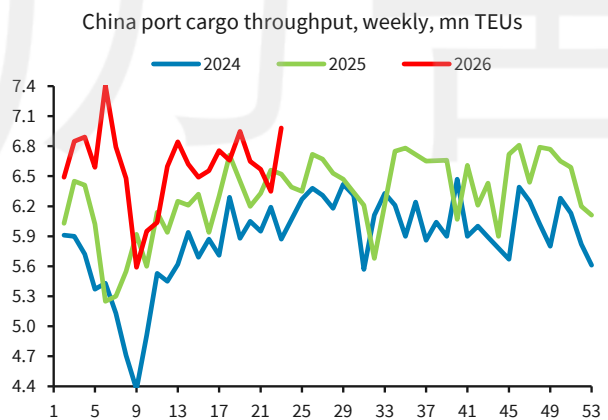
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 3. High-tech manufacturing PMI improved in May amid strong AI and green-tech exports



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. Shipping data suggested strength in exports extended into May



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

Next week, inflation, trade and credit data are in focus

- Trade (9 June): We expect export growth to remain double-digits, at 14% y/y, in May thanks to strong export demand for green-tech and AI related products. We expect import growth of 25% y/y in May amid rising commodity and semiconductor prices.
- Credit (9-15 June): We expect growth in total social financing to hit a record low of 7.7% y/y in May, from 7.8%, in view of weaker household credit demand linked to property sales.
- Inflation (10 June): We expect CPI inflation to remain flat at 1.2% y/y in May as higher energy prices were offset by food deflation (led by pork). We expect PPI inflation to rise to 4.0% y/y in May, from 2.8%, in view of continued increases in commodity prices, including base metals (copper and steel) and energy (coal and oil).

CHINA DATA REVIEW & PREVIEW

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Review of last week's data releases

Main indicators	Period	Previous	Barclays	Actual	Comments
China: NBS manufacturing PMI, index	May	50.3	50.0	50.0	PMIs point to a bifurcated landscape
China: NBS non-manufacturing PMI, index	May	49.4	49.5	50.1	
China: RatingDog manufacturing PMI, index	May	52.2	52.0	51.8	

Preview of upcoming data

Sunday, 07 June	Period	Prev 2	Prev 1	Latest	Forecast	Consensus
- China: Foreign reserves, USD bn	May	3427.8	3342.1	3410.5	3400.0	3400.0
China: We expect FX reserves to fall by USD10bn to USD3.4trn in May largely due to negative valuation effects linked to a weaker EUR.						

Tuesday, 09 June	Period	Prev 2	Prev 1	Latest	Forecast	Consensus
- China: M2 growth, % y/y (to 15/06)	May	8.3	8.7	8.6	8.5	8.6
- China: Aggregate financing stock, CNY trn (to 15/06)	May	451.4	456.5	456.9	458.9	-
- China: New loans, CNY bn (to 15/06)	May	900.0	2990.0	-10.0	500.0	-
- China: Trade balance, USD bn	May	90.5	50.6	84.8	95.0	91.0
- China: Exports, % y/y	May	39.6	2.5	14.1	14.0	15.0
- China: Imports, % y/y	May	13.8	27.8	25.3	25.0	26.5

China: We expect growth in total social financing to hit a record low of 7.7% y/y in May, from 7.8%, in view of weaker household credit demand linked to property sales. We expect export growth to remain double-digit at 14% y/y in May thanks to strong export demand for green-tech and AI related products. We expect import growth of 25% y/y in May amid rising commodity and semiconductor prices.

Wednesday, 10 June	Period	Prev 2	Prev 1	Latest	Forecast	Consensus
09:30 China: PPI, % y/y	May	-0.9	0.5	2.8	4.0	3.8
09:30 China: CPI, % y/y	May	1.3	1.0	1.2	1.2	1.3

China: We expect CPI inflation to remain flat at 1.2% y/y in May as higher energy prices were offset by food deflation (led by pork). We expect PPI inflation to rise to 4.0% y/y in May, from 2.8%, in view of continued increases in commodity prices, including base metals (copper and steel) and energy (coal and oil).

Note: Bloomberg consensus forecasts and release dates are subject to change.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

CHINA SNAPSHOT

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	2025				2026				2027				Calendar year average		
% change y/y	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1E	Q2E	Q3E	Q4E	Q1E	Q2E	Q3E	Q4E	2025	2026E	2027E
Real GDP (% y/y)	5.4	5.2	4.8	4.5	5.0	4.7	4.4	4.3	3.7	3.9	4.1	4.2	5.0	4.6	4.0
Real GDP (% q/q saar)	5.6	4.3	3.6	4.4	6.8	3.2	3.2	4.0	4.5	4.1	4.1	4.1	...	...	...
Real GDP (% y/y YTD)	5.4	5.3	5.2	5.0	5.0	4.8	4.7	4.6	3.7	3.8	3.9	4.0	...	...	...
Consumption (pp)	2.8	2.8	2.8	2.6	2.4	2.0	2.0	2.0	1.9	1.8	2.0	2.0	2.6	2.0	2.0
Investment (pp)	0.5	1.0	0.9	0.8	1.9	1.4	1.3	1.2	1.1	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.8	1.2	1.0
Net exports (pp)	2.1	1.5	1.5	1.6	0.8	1.4	1.4	1.4	0.7	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.6	1.4	1.0
Industrial production (% y/y)	6.5	6.2	5.8	5.0	6.1	5.2	4.9	4.8	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	5.9	5.2	4.5
Nominal GDP (% y/y)	4.6	3.9	3.7	3.9	4.9	5.0	5.0	4.9	4.3	4.5	4.7	4.7	4.0	5.2	4.6
CPI inflation (% y/y)	-0.1	0.0	-0.2	0.5	0.8	0.5	0.7	0.9	1.3	1.2	0.8	0.0	0.1	0.7	0.8
Surveyed unemployment rate (%)	5.2	5.0	5.2	5.1	5.4	5.1	5.1	5.1	5.2	5.1	5.2	5.1	5.1	5.1	5.1
Current account (% GDP)	3.7	2.7	4.0	4.4	4.0	4.0	4.0	4.0	4.0	4.0	4.0	4.0	3.7	4.0	4.0
Government balance (% GDP)	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	-4.0	-4.0	-4.0
Central government debt (% GDP)	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	29.1	32.8	36.5
7d OMO rate (%)	1.50	1.40	1.40	1.40	1.40	1.30	1.30	1.30	1.30	1.30	1.30	1.30	1.40	1.30	1.30

Note: All numbers are expressed in y/y % change unless otherwise specified. Contributions by GDP expenditure components are all reported as "year to date" numbers officially.

Source: Barclays Research

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